

WRDS Overview of IBES

WRDS Overview of I/B/E/S Historical Earnings Estimate Database. The I/B/E/S estimate database contains analysts forecast data.

Introduction

I/B/E/S, the Institutional Brokers' Estimate System, is a database from LSEG. It is an historical earnings estimate database containing analyst estimates for more than 20 forecast measures - including EPS (earnings per share), revenue, price targets, EBITDA and pre-tax profits - available on both consensus and detailed levels, covering both U.S. and international companies. The database also includes buy-hold-sell recommendations.

I/B/E/S History is a comprehensive expectation database and is ideal for research and back-testing of investment theories and proprietary models.

I/B/E/S Guidance is a related, but separate, product from LSEG that includes management's predictions about their own company (as opposed to the opinions of 3rd party analysts). It includes information previously available in the Company Issued Guidance (CIG) file in base I/B/E/S and information from the defunct First Call database.

I/B/E/S Global Aggregates is add-on product that provides earnings forecasts for countries and major international indices.

I/B/E/S KPI is an add-on product covering predictions of key performance indicators. These are metrics specific to an industry and may include sales per square foot in retail or number of bed-days in healthcare. An overview of I/B/E/S KPI can be [found here](#).

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Coverage

I/B/E/S has forecast information on 60,000 companies across 100+ markets. The following table shows the detailed information (Date ranges include years with at least 200 observations).

Table 1: I/B/E/S Ticker coverage (as of Sept. 2025) in earnings estimate database

Distinct I/B/E/S Tickers	U.S.	International
Detail History	25,142	60,626
Summary History	22,498	54,120

Table 2: FPEDATS coverage (as of Feb 2015) in earnings estimate database

Forecast period end date(FPEDATS)	U.S.	International
EPS measure - Detail History	1980 - 2036	1982 - 2048
Non-EPS measure - Detail History	1992 - 2034	1982 - 2048
EPS measure - Summary History	1975 - 2030	1975 - 2030
Non-EPS measure Summary History	1989 - 2030	1982 - 2030

The following measures are currently available in I/B/E/S on WRDS:

- Earnings Per Share (EPS)
- Book Value Per Share (BPS)
- Cash Flow Per Share (CPS)
- Capital Expenditure (Non per share,CPX)
- Cash Earnings Per Share (CSH)
- Dividend Per Share (DPS)
- Earnings Per Share - Before Goodwill (EBG)
- EBIT (Non Per Share, EBI)
- EBITDA Per Share (EBS)

- EBITDA (Non Per Share, EBT)
- Enterprise Value (Non Per Share, ENT)
- Earnings Per Share - Alternate (EPX)
- Funds From Operations Per Share (FFO)
- GAAP/Earnings Per Share - Fully Reported (GPS)
- Gross Margin (Percent, GRM)
- Net Asset Value (Non Per Share, NAV)
- Net Debt (NDT)
- Net Income (Non Per Share, NET)
- Operating Profit (Non Per Share, OPR)
- Pre-tax Profit (Non Per Share, PRE)
- Return on Assets (Percent, ROA)
- Return on Equity (Percent, ROE)
- Revenue (Non Per Share, SAL)

The database contains estimate data for up to ten(or more than 10 years in the future) Annual Fiscal Periods, twelve(or more than 12 quarters in the future) Quarter Fiscal Periods, six(or Semi annual without an actual or more than 6 semi annual periods in the future) Semi annual Periods, and Long Term Growth. Page 44 of the [manual](#) gives the detail.

Data Collection Process

More than 3,000 estimators (brokers) contribute data to I/B/E/S from the largest global houses to regional and local brokers, totaling over 30,000 individual analysts. Company actuals are collected from multiple news wire feeds, press releases, company websites and public filings. Detailed estimates are collected each day as they are released by analysts. Summary history consists of chronological snapshots of consensus level data taken on a monthly basis. The snapshots are as of the Thursday before the third Friday of every month.

Prior to 1993, Detail History was a reconstruction of archived detail tapes. Extensive audits were performed to preserve the integrity of the original data.

For a variety of reasons (restricted lists, corporate announcements, etc.) an analyst may discontinue his/her earnings estimates on an individual security. In the source files for the Detail History there is no explicit indicator of this occurrence for periods before June 1993. Stop dates were calculated based on an algorithm.

For a company to be available in the I/B/E/S

History files there must have been at least one analyst providing estimate forecasts for the company.

If an estimate has not been updated or confirmed for 180 days it is stopped. LSEG reviews each estimate carefully, especially around events such as company guidance or stock splits. Any estimates that appear not to have taken updated information into account are excluded from the database.

There may be cases where a company is no longer in existence or analysts are no longer contributing forecasts. Estimates will remain in I/B/E/S History in these cases. This helps keep the database free from survivorship bias. However, the brokers maintain the intellectual property of the estimates and occasionally ask that their data be anonymized or removed. Anonymized means the estimator ID is set to missing or 0. In some cases, most notably UBS, all historical records were removed. LSEG reports (in June 2022) that approximately 10-12 brokers have requested all historical data be removed.

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Dataset Organization

File Location Description

The table below lists I/B/E/S products (please note 'Historical Earnings Estimates', 'Guidance' and 'Global Aggregates' are separate products, each requires individual permission.), as well as their respective SAS, Postgres, and Unix locations. For further information, [visit the product page on the WRDS website](#).

File Location Table

Table 1: Table Locations

Product	SAS Libname / Postgres schema name	Unix Location
I/B/E/S Historical Earnings Estimates	ibes	/wrds/ibes/ sasdata

Product	SAS Libname / Postgres schema name	Unix Location
I/B/E/S Guidance	ibes	/wrds/ibes/ sasdata/ guidance
I/B/E/S Global Aggregates	ibes	/wrds/ibes/ sasdata/iga

Datasets Created by WRDS

WRDS modifies the original data in two ways: we add identifiers and group files with similar content.

The EPS measure is the most popular and is stored in its own **_EPS** tables. All other measures are combined into **_XEPS** tables. For example, **DET_EPSUS** contains detailed EPS estimates for US companies. For further information, please see [WRDS Note on IBES - October 2010](#).

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Linking

Identifiers Used

The I/B/E/S ticker, denoted as 'TICKER', is a unique identifier assigned to each security that is consistent throughout I/B/E/S History. When two companies that are both represented in the LSEG universe merge, the new company may change CUSIP/SEDOL, company name, or Official Ticker, as well as any other identifiers. However, the I/B/E/S ticker for the acquiring company will not change. This is done to preserve a historical timeline for the new company. In the LSEG historical databases, all data relating to the acquired company will stop as of the acquisition date. OFTIC represents the official exchange ticker, meaning that it often changes and is reused. It is important not to confuse the I/B/E/S ticker (which is good for linking) with the exchange ticker (which is not good for linking).

I/B/E/S databases also provide CUSIPs, which are historical.

To link I/B/E/S with other databases from LSEG, please refer to [this document](#).

To link I/B/E/S with CRSP, please refer to [this document](#).

No extra work is needed for linking with Compustat, since Compustat already provides the linking information in table 'SECURITY'(comp.security) for North America companies or 'G_SECURITY'(comp.g_security) for global companies. Item 'IBTIC' represents the I/B/E/S ticker symbol in those two tables.

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Database Notes

I/B/E/S Terminology

There are quite a few terms that are specific to I/B/E/S and/or the estimates industry. Understanding these terms is crucial to understanding the database. Below is the list

- Estimator: Sell-side institution or contributor. In the past, I/B/E/S used 'Broker'.
- Analyst: Person at the sell-side institution or contributing analyst who makes the forecast.
- Estimate: A prediction from the analyst about future earnings or another measure for a specific issue/entity and time period.
- Detailed estimate: Analyst-by-analyst estimates.
- Consensus (summary) estimate: The average of all(subjects to I/B/E/S [exclusion rules](#)) estimates, from all analysts, for a given issue and time period.
- Actual: The reported value by the company of earnings or another measure for a specific issue/entity and time period; to be compared against the estimate.
- Measure: The metric for which the estimate is made. Earnings per share (EPS) is the most popular measure.

Estimator(Broker)/Analyst Translation File

Brokers and analysts are represented by codes to hide their real names. LSEG does not provide academics with the Estimator/Analyst translation file. WRDS no longer has a copy of this file either.

Dates

Announce date(ANNDATS) is the date that the forecast/actual was reported.

Activation date(ACTDATS) is the date that the forecast/actual was recorded by LSEG.

Forecast Period End Date (FPEDATS) is the date to which the estimate applies. For 70% of the companies, an estimate for a particular fiscal year will have an FPEDATS of December 31st of that year.

The FPI (forecast period indicator)

Because not all companies have the same fiscal year end, LSEG uses FPI (a numeric value or one-character code) to identify estimates for each unique period.

Using the reported periods as a base, the period end dates for all estimated periods are easily calculated. For example, if December 2007 is the last reported annual (assume the calendar year = the fiscal year), the FPI=1, FPI=2 and FPI=3 estimates are for the periods ending December 2008, 2009 and 2010, respectively. Please note FPI=0 is for long term growth.

Please check out the following knowledge base article for better understanding of this variable - [Examining FPI](#)

The PDF (Primary/Diluted Flag) or PDI (Primary/Diluted Indicator)

Primary/Diluted Flags (PDF) in the detail history file are Estimate specific. While Primary/Diluted Indicators (PDI) in the Identifier file are company specific.

Please check out the knowledge base article [Estimates on a Primary vs. Diluted basis](#) for detailed information.

Adjusted and Unadjusted

In the set of adjusted files, all per share measures data including Price Targets are adjusted for corporate actions represented as splits.

To merge unadjusted actuals and ID data into detail history unadjusted data, please check out [this document](#).

Normalized History Files

LSEG follows companies based on their reporting currency. However in some cases where the reporting currency does not reflect the clear majority of estimate submissions, LSEG may exercise the option to set the default based on the

currency of the majority of estimate submissions. In cases where companies report in multiple currencies, LSEG will set the default currency based on the majority of estimate submissions. As a result of currency fluctuations over time, starting in April 2009, LSEG introduced an additional set of I/B/E/S Normalized historical files that include summary and detail data with normalized company default currencies. This new offering provides a smooth historical view of companies that have had a currency change over time and is intended to simplify clients' workflow.

On WRDS, the set of normalized files have file names starting with the letter 'n', which are accessible via the data dictionary.

Academic vs. Institutional Versions

While many brokers allow all I/B/E/S clients to access their estimates, certain brokers require licenses directly with each client to use their estimates. The detailed estimates for these brokers do not appear in the academic version, but are still included in the calculation of the consensus figures. The consensus estimates are the same for both Academic and Institutional versions.

Database Changes Over Time

LSEG reminds researchers that I/B/E/S is a living database and is not meant to be used for point-in-time research.

- Brokers may be removed from the database upon their request, as described above. This process (called "going post-approval" by I/B/E/S), removes the broker and any analysts working for them from the data. WRDS is not sure if this includes an analyst estimates during a period they were working at a different brokerage. These estimates are not included in I/B/E/S going forward, but these estimates are still included in Summary data. Therefore, there should be consistent and perpetual drift between Summary and Details data over time.
- Analysts within Price Target files are able to further become "anonymous". This issue stopped at one point in time but has becoming recurring.
- Broker and analyst IDs may change. They are consistent over time within a given

dataset. The process of anonymization <https://wrds-www.wharton.upenn.edu/pages/support...> changed in 2018 and IDs were changed historically. These IDs are also subject to be changed without warning upon any new I/B/E/S data update. Further, these IDs were changed in the past (though the extent of these changes are unknown) prior to the 2018 event mentioned.

- I/B/E/S data is currently missing price target data from large brokers over time. It is unclear why this issue occurs.
- It may be the case that quarterly EPS estimates do not sum to annual estimates. While this is the case for an estimate exclusion by I/B/E/S' data cleaning standards, it appears that this may be a necessary but insufficient condition. No reason for why these cases exist is known at this time.
- Consensus data may be corrected in the days and weeks following their release. Figures older than 6 months are generally stable but exceptions arise.
- Mistakes in any part of the database can be corrected at any time.

LSEG prohibits WRDS and individual researchers from retaining snapshots of the database over time. Further, researchers are prohibited from de-anonymizing broker or analysts from their masked IDs.

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Additional Resources

- [Vendor Manuals](#)
- [Sample Programs](#)
- [Research Applications](#)

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